



SECOND SEMESTER 2025-26
COURSE HANDOUT

Date: 31.07.2026

In addition to part I (General Handout for all courses appended to the Time table) this portion gives further specific details regarding the course.

Course No : HSSF349
Course Title : ECOCRITICISM
Instructor-in-Charge : Susan Haris (susan.haris@pilani.bits-pilani.ac.in)

1. Course Description: Ecocriticism has found its place in the Indian academy only in the last twenty years or so. The course is intended to familiarize the learners with ecological, deep ecological and *tinai* critical principles and show them how these could be effective critical tools. The course gives a humanistic perspective on how ecology is a new paradigm in cultural and literary texts. The learners will be exposed to recent ecocritical concepts which will challenge conventional attitudes and values which are detrimental to the well-being of our planet.

2. Scope and Objective of the Course:

1. To introduce the learners to one of the major postmodern critical trends.
2. To familiarize the learners with some key ecocritical concepts.
3. To equip the students to create ecocritical documents in literary, cinematic and other artistic forms.
4. To train the learners in the application of the critical concepts to various cultural texts.

3. Text Books: Glotfelty, Cheryl and Harold Fromm. Eds. *The Ecocriticism Reader: Landmarks in Literary Ecology*. Athens and London: U of Georgia Press, 1996. Print.

Alex, Rayson K, S. Susan Deborah and Sachindev P.S. Eds. *Culture and Media: Ecocritical Explorations*. London: Cambridge Scholars Publishing, 2013.

4. Reference Books:

Garrard, Greg. *Ecocriticism*. Routledge, 2004.

Buell, Lawrence. *The Environmental Imagination: Thoreau, Nature Writing, and the Formation of American Culture*. Harvard UP, 1995.

Nixon, Rob. *Slow Violence and the Environmentalism of the Poor*. Harvard UP, 2011.

Huggan, Graham, and Helen Tiffin. *Postcolonial Ecocriticism: Literature, Animals, Environment*. Routledge, 2010.

5. Course Plan:



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Lecture	Lecture session	References (along with primary texts)	Learning outcomes
1-2	Literature and ecological attention	Rilke's "The Panther"	Introduce how literature represents inaccessible experience
3-5	Umwelt or the subjective world	Uexkull's <i>Umwelt</i>	Introduce theory about subjective experience
6-8	What is ecocriticism?	Garrard, Ecocriticism (Intro)	Define ecocriticism
9-11	Imagining the nonhuman	"The Author of Acacia Seeds" by Ursula Le Guin	Examine how fiction imagines nonhuman communication
12-14	What makes a text environmental?	Buell, Intro Environmental Imagination	Identify and evaluate "environmental text"
15-17	Environment as Presence	Snakes, A River by A.K. Ramanujan	Apply Buell in the Indian context
	Beyond the heroic narrative	Ursula Le Guin, The Carrier Bag Theory	Explain how narrative shapes what counts as action and knowledge
18-20	Reading environment as presence	<i>Valli</i> , selected opening paras	Is the forest merely where the story occurs or more?
21-23	Environmental tropes and questions	Continue with <i>Valli</i>	How is the pastoral transformed?
24-26	Deep ecology and intrinsic value	Basic Principles of Deep Ecology by Arne Næss and George Sessions	Explain intrinsic value, ecological interconnectedness, and biospheric egalitarianism
27-29	Postcolonial critiques of environmentalism	Radical American Environmentalism and Wilderness Preservation: A Third World Critique by Ramachandra Guha	Explain how a universal environmentalism is complicated
30-32	Slow violence: definition, temporality, invisibility	Nixon, Slow Violence	connect time/scale to narrative difficulty.
33-35	Extinction and biodiversity	Ursula K. Heise, <i>Imagining Extinction</i>	How is ecological loss represented?
36-38	Extinction as relational loss	Thom van Dooren, "Pain of Extinction: The Death of a Vulture"	Situate ecological loss and grief
39-40	Extinction as Relational loss	W.S. Merwin "For a Coming Extinction"	Demonstrate how narrative anticipates and represents
41-42	Ecocriticism and Human-wildlife conflict	Introduction of <i>Interspecies Negotiations</i>	Connect history to form.

6. Evaluation Scheme:



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Component	Duration	Weightage (%)	Date & Time	Nature of component (Close Book/ Open Book)
Mid-Semester Test	90 Min.	25	5/10/FN	CB
Comprehensive Examination	3 h	35	11/12/2026 FN	CB
Assignment 1 (Reading Notes)		30		Open book
Assignment 2		10		Open book

7. Chamber Consultation Hour: 6170 B, 10-11 am Monday.

8. Notices: All the readings and announcements will be posted on Google classroom

9. Make-up Policy: Will be allowed if there is a genuine reason and the student reaches out to me promptly.

10. Attendance Policy: Class participation is essential to follow the readings.

11. Minimum passing Marks criteria:

12. Note (if any):

Instructor-in-charge Susan Haris
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